

Complete Photo Restoration

Sometimes, old photos are so badly damaged that the print has almost completely been replaced by the whiteness of the paper. It is impossible to restore such photos to their original splendour. You can, however, use a popular technique called airbrushing to improve the pictures.



Use the Airbrush function in Photoshop to restore photos such as the one on the left, to fill in missing areas and make it look like the picture on the right ...

An actual airbrush is a mechanical brush that uses no bristles to apply the paint. Instead, compressed air is forced through a fine nozzle to break up the paint into an ultra fine mist. This effect can be effectively replicated in Adobe Photoshop with precision. Through this technique, the missing elements of the picture are literally drawn back into the photo. The end result may not look extremely real, but it's the best restoration technique available for completely damaged pictures. You can even convert old black and white photos into colour using the airbrush technique.



TIP

One of the great hidden features on digital cameras is the fill flash or flash on mode. By taking control of the flash so it goes on when you want it to, not when the camera deems it appropriate, you have taken an important step toward capturing great outdoor portraits. In flash on mode, the camera exposes for the background first, then adds just enough flash to illuminate your portrait subject. The result is a professional looking picture where everything in the composition looks good. After you get the hang of using the flash outdoors, try a couple variations on the theme by positioning the subject so the sun illuminates the hair from the side or the back, often referred to as rim lighting. Another good technique is to put the model in the shade under a tree, then use the flash to illuminate the subject. Remember that most inbuilt camera flashes only have a range of 10 feet, so make sure you don't stand too far away when using fill flash outdoors.